

IMAGINARY MONEY

Here's what I imagined would happen when I got a credit card, having done no research on what happens when you get a credit card:

I walk into the bank. The tellers all stare at me. They smirk. I am prey. I look around the bank, unsure of what to do next. Is someone supposed to come up to you and ask what you want? Do you (as in a restaurant maybe) seat yourself? I see there's a line of people waiting to speak to a teller, but there're also people waiting in chairs to meet with someone in an office. If I wait in the line and then get to the teller and she says, "What? To get a credit card, you have to go talk to a person in an office. Everyone knows that, you moron," then I can never return to this bank. End scene.

When did everyone else learn these things that I imagine are so obvious to the rest of the bank's patrons? Why do I care what the tellers think? I imagine them all going to lunch together and laughing at me. "Can you believe someone reached her age and didn't know who to talk to about getting a credit card?" they'd cackle over pad thai.

Until way late in the game, I had no idea you could get a credit card from anywhere other than a bank. Bank of America (BoA) was the bank my parents used, and that's the only one that gave me any sense of familiarity. When I was kid, the tellers handed me and my sister lollipops for good behavior. I probably had some Pavlovian loyalty to the chain. (Do *all* banks do this?)

When I was a year out of college, I went into a BoA near my apartment in Harlem and got my first credit card. I asked the teller for one credit card, please. I did not know what a credit card was used for other than to get yourself into trouble.

I'm obviously not known for my restraint, but my parents insisted I get a credit card so I could start building a credit score and sign the leases for my own apartments. A terrifying chain of events. At Bank of America, they had me pose